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From Followers to Founders: Influencer Made Products in Consumer Markets

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Abstract. What drives the success of influencer made products remains an open question as most existing influencer marketing research focuses on paid endorsements rather than influencers acting as product creators and owners. Building on prior work on influencer authenticity, congruence between influencer and product, engagement quality, and follower trust, this research will examine how influencer attributes such as authenticity, audience fit, and follower engagement interact with product level characteristics including product visibility in content and various other factors. Unlike earlier studies that evaluate campaign effectiveness or influencer selection, this project shifts the unit of analysis to influencer owned products, allowing engagement and trust to translate directly into market outcomes. By linking influencer content, engagement measures, and influencer persona, the study extends past research by showing when influencer social capital converts into sustainable product success rather than short term attention or hype.

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Key words: Influencer Marketing,

1. Introduction

1.1. Overview of influencer marketing

Influencer marketing is when a brand pays or collaborates with a social media creator to promote something to their followers in a way that feels personal or authentic. In brand influencer marketing the way to get an influencer to show off your product follows four simple steps:

1. A brand finds an influencer whose audience matches their target market
2. The influencer creates content featuring the product
3. Followers see the recommendation from someone they trust
4. Which leads to an increase in awareness, trust, and sales for the brand

Influencer marketing has been a topic of concern for marketers since the dark ages of marketing. However, as of 2012, Influencer marketing has become mainstream driven by the rise of image-focused social media platforms. It has been over a decade since then and influencer marketing has exploded and changed in many vast ways. Several research projects have been explored to detail how best to be an influencer and how best to use an influencer for your brand. There is even a break down into the type of influencer they are based on the number of followers they have.

1.2. Research gap

If there are so many projects on this topic you may be asking why is there yet another paper diving deep into the real of realism that is influencer marketing. I give you one simple question in return: Where the gap is in the research? The most notable gap in the various literature about influencer marketing is that little is known about what brings value to an influencer made product. For example, what about Mr.Beast or Logan Paul drives the success or failure of their products. Furthermore, what is it about Shaquille O'Neal that gives him the ability to slap his name or face on a product and it becomes a best seller.

1.3. Research question

The research question we will be studying in this paper is about influencer made products. Specifically, what about an influencer makes their product valuable in the eyes of the consumers? Could it be that the amount of followers or comments establish trust and credibility? or is their something else sprinkled on top, hidden to the naked eye?

2. Theoretical Background and Literature Review

2.1. Influencer Marketing in Prior Research

2.2. Observable Influencer Characteristics

There are many observable Characteristics that many other research mention that are important to determining the value an influencer can bring to a brand.

2.3. Trust, Credibility, and Consumer Response

3. Methodology

3.1. Deliverable 6 begins

3.2. Conjoint

Due to the lack of information on the subject of influencer made products it is hard to tell if those same variables will have similar effects or if need new variables entirely. I propose a combination of both. Using elements most commonly used in the other research papers, we can design a survey and conjoint analysis to access the value of the these variables when influencer make their own

product for consumer markets. The new variables included will only be included in the conjoint analysis.

Respondents were shown 12 choice sets each with two choices within in them. The choices had the attributes randomly placed outside of the product image which was left at the top to help with visualization of the product. The levels were alos given to each respondent randomly so as to avoid bias.

The baseline (reference) levels for the conjoint analysis were selected to represent realistic, non-extreme, and conceptually neutral options so that estimated utilities can be interpreted as improvements relative to a typical influencer collaboration. For influencer persona, a philanthropic creator was chosen as the reference category because it is less polarizing than a controversial personality and less status-dominant than a celebrity, athlete, or entrepreneur, making it a neutral comparison point. For audience size, 1 million followers was used as the baseline because it represents a realistic mid-tier influencer rather than a mega-celebrity or a very small creator. Engagement measures were anchored at their lowest plausible levels, with 1,000 comments and 100,000 likes serving as reference categories, allowing higher engagement levels to be interpreted as added value. Posting activity was similarly anchored at the lowest level, with one post per month as the baseline, enabling the effects of more frequent posting to be measured relative to a minimally active account. Finally, for the product attribute, the image in the fourth level was selected as the baseline because this represents the simplest and least feature-rich collaboration format, allowing more complex deliverables to be interpreted as incremental enhancements.

3.2.1. Attributes and levels There are six different attributes we will be testing on in the conjoint analysis. These attributes are listed below with descriptions of each of the attributes as well as the number of levels in each one. Please see Figure 1 to see the specific levels within each attribute.

Attributes	Level 1	Level 2	Level 3	Level 4	Level 5	Level 6	Level 7	Level 8		Number of Levels
Product										7
Influencer Persona	Philanthropic creator	Controversial internet personality	active professional athlete	professional athlete Retired	Mainstream celebrity entertainer	Business focused entrepreneur				6
Number of Followers	1 Million	10 Million	100 Million	250 Million	500+ Million					5
Number of comments	50,000+	25,000	10,000	5,000	1,000					5
Number of Likes	1+ million	750,000	500,000	250,00	100,000					5
Post Frequency	1 post per day	5 per week	3 posts per week	2 posts per month	1 post per month					5
									Total Levels	33
									Total Attributes	6

Figure 1 Conjoint Attributes and Levels

- Product - This is an image of the product. The images were AI generated to appear like other candy bars produced by influencers in the market today. This is one of the new attributes that will is more or less there to give the respondents something to visualize. This attribute has the most levels coming out to seven.
- Influencer Persona - influencers everywhere carry a certain persona about themselves. Some are the retired professional athlete and others are the controversial internet personality to give some examples of the levels that were used. This is another one of the new attributes. This attribute has six levels. The personas are based on mega influencers in the market currently.
- Number of Followers - This is the number of followers the influencer has on their social media page. It ranges from 1 million followers to 500+ followers. It has five levels. The range is so vast because to be considered a mega influencer the influencer needs at least 1 million followers.
- Number of Comments - This is the number of comments the influencer's post received from viewers. It ranges from 1,000 comments to 50,000+ comments. This attribute has five levels. Comments on posts tend to be lower than the influencers follower count due to the amount of effort the viewer has to put into making the comment.
- Number of Likes - this is the number of likes the influencer's post received from the viewers. It ranges from 100,000 likes to 1+ million likes. This attribute has five levels. The range is not as vast as the number of followers, but consumers are quite picky as to what they leave a like on and often it is not the ads made for products.
- Post Frequency - This is how often the influencer posts. Influencers may post every day of every week or as little as once a month. It often depends on the influencer how often they wish to post and the audience the influencer is speaking to.

3.3. Survey Measures

3.3.1. Likert scale items

3.3.2. Demographic Information

3.4. Sample and Data Collection

The sample size of the data we collected included 250 respondents. The website conjointly.com was used to create the conjoint analysis and the online panel website prolific was used to gather the data. Respondents were paid to incentives good survey taking. The survey itself was 28 questions long with a block of 12 choice sets for the conjoint analysis. The Respondents were shown two choices in each set to pick from. Within the survey there were some questions asked to screen the

respondents out in case they had not interacted with mega influencers before. This was done to avoid noise in the data and to avoide a coverage bias.

4. Results

4.1. Significant positive effects

4.2. Significant negative effects

4.3. Non-significant effects

5. Discussion

5.1. Theoretical Contributions

5.2. Managerial Implications

5.3. Limitations

One of the largest and most prominent limitation reflected in this project is that we only ran the conjoint analysis on chocolate bars. To improve and continue the research would mean to add new products and determine the cross category effects on the market. What is the difference between a fashion influencer who makes clothes and accessories and a snack influencer who makes a variety of snacks for the market?

6. Conclusion

The From Followers to Founders project has discovered....(hopefully something cool)

6.1. Deliverable 6 ends

Notes

Acknowledgments

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